

Confessions of *Cheating Girlfriend II*

Lies, lust and
sneaking upstairs
Part 2

JJ Vale



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I went downstairs to my apartment and straight to the shower. I washed carefully, methodically, erasing any trace of Myles from my body. But I couldn't erase the feeling, the knowledge of what we had done, what we would do again.

When my boyfriend Silas came home at four I was on the couch reading. He kissed the top of my head and went to the kitchen.

"How was your day?" he asked.

"Quiet. I wasn't feeling well so I stayed home."

"You feeling better now?"

"Much better."

He made himself a sandwich and settled next to me on the couch. We watched television while he ate. His leg pressed against mine, familiar and comfortable. I felt nothing. No guilt, no shame, no affection. Just the absence of feeling, like I was watching my life from outside my body.

That night he reached for me in bed. His hand slid under my shirt, cupping my breast. I let him, curious what I would feel. His touch was tentative, routine. He kissed my neck and I compared it to the way Myles had kissed me there, hungry and sure. There was no comparison.

"I'm tired," I said.

"Okay." He rolled away without protest.

I lay in the dark listening to him breathe and thought about tomorrow morning. Monday. I could make it until Monday.

Saturday dragged. Silas worked on his thesis. I cleaned things that were already clean, went to the grocery store, made dinner. We ate in silence and went to bed early. He fell asleep immediately. I stared at the ceiling and counted hours.

Sunday morning I woke at six. Silas was still asleep. I dressed in leggings and a sports bra, clothes I never wore, and went to the living room. I put on running shoes I had bought years ago and never used.

When Silas emerged at seven, stretching and yawning, I was doing lunges in the living room.

"What are you doing?" he asked.

"I'm going to start running. I need to get more active."

He looked at me like I had suggested joining the circus. "Since when?"

"Since now. I'm out of shape and I feel gross."

"You look fine."

"Thanks, but I'm still going."

I left before he could ask more questions. Outside the morning was cool and quiet. I stretched on the front lawn, counting to sixty, then I went up the stairs to the main house and knocked on apartment 12.

Myles opened the door immediately, like he had been waiting. He pulled me inside and kissed me before the door even closed. His hands were already under my shirt, his mouth already on my neck.

"I thought about you all day yesterday," he said between kisses.

"Me too."

"Tell me how long I have you."

"An hour. Maybe two if I say I ran far."

"Then we better not waste time."

We moved to the couch this time. He sat and pulled me onto his lap, facing him. I could feel him already hard beneath his shorts. I ground down against him and he groaned into my mouth.

"You're going to kill me," he said.

"Good."

His hands slid under my sports bra, pushing it up. He took my breast in his mouth while his hand worked the other. I rocked against him, seeking friction, seeking relief. The material between us was thin enough that I could feel the shape of him, thick and ready.

"Take this off," he said, tugging at my top.

I pulled it over my head. His eyes went dark as he looked at me.

"Perfect," he said. "You're perfect."

His mouth moved between my breasts while his hands gripped my hips, guiding my movements. I was already wet, already aching for more. I reached between us and palmed him through his shorts.

"Not yet," he said, catching my hand. "I told you. Next time."

"This is next time."

"Next time after next time." He lifted me and laid me on the couch, settling between my legs. "I want to take this slow. Want to learn every part of you first."

His hand slid into my leggings, under my underwear. When his fingers found me wet and ready he made a satisfied sound.

"All this for me?" he asked.

"Yes."

He stroked me slowly, his thumb circling while two fingers slid inside. I gasped and my hips lifted. He worked me with practiced skill, watching my face, learning what made me gasp, what made my eyes roll back.

"That's it," he said. "Let me see you."

I gripped the couch cushions as the pressure built. His fingers curved inside me, hitting that spot that made everything tighten. His thumb maintained steady pressure and I felt myself climbing again, higher and faster than before.

The tension coiled tight in my core, building and building until I broke apart under his hand. My body tensed, then released in waves that rolled through me. I turned my face into the couch to muffle my sounds, aware that walls were thin, that neighbors existed, that my boyfriend was directly below us.

When I could breathe again, when the aftershocks had faded, I opened my eyes to find Myles watching me with hunger and satisfaction mixed together.

"Beautiful," he said.

The word landed wrong this time. I sat up, pulling my sports bra back down, suddenly aware of my nakedness. The fog of desire was clearing and reality rushed in to fill the space.

"I need to go," I said.

"Briana, "

"No, I really need to go. I've been gone too long already."

I found my shirt and pulled it on. My hands were shaking. Myles stood and caught my wrist, gentle but firm.

"What's wrong?"

"What's wrong? Are you serious?" I pulled away from him. "This is wrong. All of this. I have a boyfriend downstairs and I'm up here with you and what are we even doing?"

"We're enjoying each other."

"That's a nice way of saying I'm cheating on him."

"Are you happy with him?"

"That's not the point."

"It's exactly the point," Myles said. "If you were happy, you wouldn't be here."

"Maybe I'm just a terrible person."

"You're not terrible. You're just human."

I shook my head. The guilt that had been background noise suddenly filled my skull, loud and insistent. I thought about Silas downstairs, probably still in bed, trusting me. Believing I was out running. Believing in us.

"I can't do this again," I said.

"You don't mean that."

"I do. This was a mistake."

I left before he could argue. I ran down the stairs and around the block, actually running this time, my feet pounding pavement. I ran until my lungs burned and my legs ached and I couldn't think anymore. When I finally came back, sweating and gasping, Silas was in the kitchen making coffee.

"Good run?" he asked.

"Yeah. Really good."

"You look exhausted."

"I pushed myself hard."

He nodded and poured me a cup of coffee. I took it and went to shower, standing under water as hot as I could stand, trying to wash away the guilt. But it clung to me, sticky and persistent.

I lasted three days.

Three days of avoiding the laundry room, of taking the long way to my car so I wouldn't see Myles's door, of jumping every time I heard footsteps overhead. Three days of lying next to Silas at night feeling like a stranger in my own skin. Three days of telling myself I would stop, I had stopped, it was over.

On Thursday evening I went upstairs with a basket of laundry.

He was there. Of course he was there. He looked up when I entered and something passed between us, an acknowledgment of inevitability.

"Hey," he said.

"Hi."

We loaded our machines in silence. The air felt charged, dangerous. I kept my distance, staying on my side of the room. But I could feel him watching me. When I bent to add detergent, when I closed the washer lid, when I finally turned to face him.

"I'm sorry about Sunday," he said. "I pushed too hard."

"No, I just, I freaked out. It's not your fault."

"Is it over then? Are we done?"

I should have said yes. Should have ended it cleanly while I still could. Instead I said nothing, and my silence was answer enough.

He crossed the room to me. His hand cupped my face and I leaned into the touch despite myself.

"I can't stop thinking about you," he said.

"I can't stop thinking about you either. That's the problem."

"Why is it a problem?"

"Because I feel like I'm being torn in half. When I'm with you I forget everything else exists. Then I go back downstairs and remember I'm living a lie. I look at Silas and I hate myself."

"Then leave him."

"It's not that simple."

"Why not?"

"Because we've built a life together. Because he loves me. Because ending it feels impossible."

"But staying feels worse."

He wasn't wrong. Every night next to Silas felt like slow suffocation. Every conversation felt hollow. Every touch felt like betrayal, not because I was sleeping with someone else but because I was pretending I wasn't.

"I don't know what to do," I said.

"Yes you do. You just don't want to do it."

He kissed me then, soft and slow. I kissed him back because I couldn't help myself, because my body made choices my mind couldn't justify. His hands slid under my shirt and I let him, guilt and desire tangled so tight I couldn't separate them.

"Come upstairs with me," he said against my mouth.

"I can't. Silas is home."

"Tell him you're doing laundry."

"For how long? An hour? Two? What happens when he comes looking for me?"

"He won't. He never does."

That hurt because it was true. Silas wouldn't come looking for me. He would assume I was fine, that I was where I said I was, because it wouldn't occur to him to question it.

"Please," Myles said. "I need you."

The need in his voice undid me. I wanted to be needed like that. Wanted to be wanted with that kind of urgency.

"Twenty minutes," I said. "That's all."

We went up to his apartment, moving fast and quiet. Inside he pushed me against the door and kissed me hard. His hands were already working at my jeans, pulling them down. I stepped out of them and let him lift me, wrapping my legs around his waist.

"Bedroom," I said.

"No time. Here."

He carried me to the couch and laid me down. My shirt came off, then my bra. His mouth found my breast while his hand slid between my legs. I was already wet, already ready. Guilt churned in my stomach even as my body responded to his touch.

"God, you're perfect," he said.

I pulled at his shirt and he yanked it over his head. His chest was muscular, defined. I ran my hands over him, learning the landscape of his body. He groaned and ground against me, still wearing his jeans but I could feel how hard he was.

"I want you so bad," he said.

"I know."

"Next time. Next time I'm going to have all of you."

"Yes."

His fingers slid inside me and I gasped. He worked me with sure strokes, his thumb circling, building me up fast. I gripped his shoulders and tried to stay quiet but small sounds escaped anyway. The knowledge that Silas was directly below us, that a ceiling and floor were all that separated us, made everything feel more intense.

"Come for me," Myles said. "I want to feel it."

The pressure built and built. His fingers curved, hitting that spot inside me. His thumb maintained steady pressure. My thighs started to shake. The guilt mixed with the pleasure until I couldn't tell them apart, until

everything was just sensation and heat and the desperate climb toward release.

It broke over me hard. My body clenched around his fingers, pulsing in waves I couldn't control. I buried my face in his shoulder to muffle my sounds. He worked me through it until I pushed his hand away, too sensitive.

"Your turn," I said when I could speak.

"No time. You need to get back."

"Myles, "

"Next time. I promise." He kissed me soft and deep. "Next time we'll do this right. All of it."

I got dressed on shaking legs. My body still hummed with the aftermath. Myles walked me to the door, his hand on my lower back.

"When?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"Tomorrow?"

"Maybe."

"I'll be here either way."

I went down the stairs feeling sick with guilt and satisfaction in equal measure. In the laundry room I moved my clothes from washer to dryer, my hands mechanical. Then I went back to the apartment.

Silas was on the couch with his laptop. He looked up when I entered.

"That took a while," he said.

"I ran into a neighbor. We got talking."

The lie came easy. Too easy. I was getting good at this, at the casual deception, at the double life.

"Dinner's in the fridge if you're hungry," he said.

"Thanks. I'll eat later."

I went to the bathroom and looked at myself in the mirror. My face was flushed, my eyes bright. I looked like someone who had just been touched, who had just fallen apart under someone's hands. I looked guilty.

I washed my face and went back out. Silas was still on the couch, still absorbed in his screen. I sat next to him and he put his arm around me without looking away from his laptop. We sat like that in silence and I felt nothing but the weight of what I was doing, who I was becoming.

That night in bed he reached for me. His hand slid under my shirt and I let him touch me, curious if I would feel anything. His hands were familiar,

careful. He kissed my neck and I thought about Myles kissing that same spot with hunger. There was no comparison.

But I let Silas continue because I owed him that much. Because maybe if I gave him my body I could convince myself I wasn't completely gone. He touched me the way he always touched me, predictable and gentle. I made the sounds I thought I should make. When he slid inside me I felt nothing but mechanical sensation, the physical fact of it without any heat.

He finished quickly. Afterward he kissed my forehead and rolled over. Within minutes he was asleep.

I lay awake staring at the ceiling, Myles's touch still on my skin, Silas's body warm beside me, and wondered who I was anymore.

I avoided him for almost a week. I did laundry at the laundromat again. I left for work early and came home late. When I heard his footsteps overhead I turned up the television. I threw myself into the mundane tasks of my life, trying to find solid ground.

Silas noticed nothing. He was absorbed in revisions to his thesis, his advisor pushing him hard on the methodology. I watched him work and felt the distance between us like physical space. We occupied the same apartment but lived in different worlds.

On Tuesday he left for a full day on campus, classes, advisor meeting, library time. He kissed my cheek on his way out the door.

"I'll be back around eight," he said.

"Okay."

"We should do something this weekend. Maybe drive to the coast."

"Sure. That sounds nice."

He left and I sat on the couch telling myself I would clean the apartment, run errands, do normal things. I made it until ten in the morning. Then I was climbing the stairs to 12.

I knocked. No answer. I knocked again, harder. Nothing. Disappointment crashed through me, sharp and irrational. I turned to leave and the door opened.

Myles stood there in basketball shorts, hair wet from the shower. When he saw me something flickered across his face, surprise, then relief, then heat.

"I thought you were done with me," he said.

"I tried to be."

"And?"

"I can't."

He pulled me inside and kissed me before the door even closed. His mouth was hungry, his hands already pulling at my clothes. I kissed him back with desperation, with the pent-up need of six days without this, without him.

"I missed you," he said against my mouth.

"Don't."

"Don't what?"

"Don't say things like that. Don't make this more than it is."

"What is it then?"

I didn't have an answer. I didn't want to examine it too closely. I just wanted to feel something other than the guilt that had been eating me alive.

"Bedroom," I said.

This time we made it to the bed. He pulled off my shirt, my bra. His mouth found my breast while his hands worked at my jeans. I lifted my hips and let him pull them off. Then I was naked and he was still half-dressed and the imbalance felt wrong.

I pushed at his shoulders. "Your turn."

He stripped quickly and stood before me. I looked at him openly this time, taking in the lean muscle, the breadth of his shoulders, the evidence of his want. He was beautiful in a way that made my chest tight.

"Come here," I said.

He moved over me, settling between my legs. His weight felt right, felt necessary. He kissed me deep and slow while his hand slid between us, fingers finding me already wet.

"You're ready for me," he said.

"Yes."

He reached for the nightstand but I caught his wrist. We both froze.

"Briana," he said carefully. "We should, "

"I know. I know we should." But I didn't let go of his wrist. I felt myself standing at the edge of something, the last boundary. Everything else we had done could be explained away, minimized. But this was different. This was the final line.

"Do you want me to stop?" he asked.

I thought about Silas. About the three years we had spent together, the life we had built. I thought about trust and promises and the person I used to be. The guilt rose up in my throat, thick and choking.

Then I thought about the way Myles looked at me. The way he made me feel seen and wanted and alive. I thought about the basement apartment and the dissertation and the slow death of living with someone who had stopped noticing I existed.

"No," I said. "Don't stop."

He reached for the nightstand again and this time I didn't stop him. I watched him roll on the condom, my heart beating fast. This was it. The moment I became someone else entirely.

He positioned himself between my legs, the head of him pressing against me. His eyes met mine.

"You're sure?" he asked.

I pulled him down into a kiss instead of answering. He pushed inside slowly and I gasped at the stretch, at the fullness. He was bigger than Silas, or maybe I was just paying more attention. Every inch felt deliberate, felt like a choice I was making with my whole body.

When he was fully inside he stopped, letting me adjust. His forehead rested against mine, his breathing ragged.

"God, Briana. You feel, "

"Don't talk. Just move."

He pulled back and thrust in again, finding a rhythm that made my eyes close. I gripped his shoulders, his back, feeling the muscles move under my hands. The guilt was still there, screaming in the back of my mind, but my body didn't care. My body wanted this, wanted him.

He angled his hips and hit something inside me that made me cry out.

"There," I said. "Right there."

He kept that angle, that rhythm, building something in me with each thrust. I wrapped my legs around him, pulling him deeper. The sounds filling the room were obscene but I didn't care anymore. I chased the pleasure building in my core, climbing toward release.

"Touch yourself," he said. "I want to feel you."

I slid my hand between us, finding the spot where we were joined. The sensation of him inside me while I touched myself pushed me closer to the edge. My thighs started to shake.

"That's it," he said. "Let go."

The pressure built and built until it broke. I clenched around him, my body pulsing in waves. He groaned and thrust harder, chasing his own

finish. I felt him stiffen, felt him pulse inside me, and then he was collapsing against me, breathing hard against my neck.

We lay tangled together while our breathing slowed. His weight was heavy on me but I didn't want him to move. I felt loose and satisfied and completely destroyed. I had done it. I had crossed every line. There was no going back now.

Eventually he pulled out and dealt with the condom. I lay there watching him move around his bedroom, this man I had just had sex with, this man who was not my boyfriend. The reality of it settled over me slowly, crushing and inevitable.

"You okay?" he asked, coming back to bed.

"No."

"Regret it?"

I thought about it honestly. My body still hummed with satisfaction. My mind screamed with guilt. "I don't know."

"Come here." He pulled me against his chest. His hand stroked my hair, gentle and easy.

I should have left immediately. Should have gotten dressed and run. Instead I stayed, letting him hold me, pretending for a few minutes that this was simple, that I was allowed to have this.

"What time does he come home?" Myles asked.

"Eight."

"Then you have hours."

"I should still go."

"Stay a little longer."

So I stayed. We dozed and when I woke he was hard against my hip. Without discussion, without hesitation, we did it again. This time I was on top, watching his face as I moved over him. This time felt different, less desperate, more deliberate. Like we were learning each other, figuring out what worked.

After, I finally got dressed. He watched me from the bed, still naked and unashamed.

"When can I see you again?" he asked.

"I don't know. This is, I can't think about this right now."

"Okay. But Briana?"

"What?"

"This isn't just sex for me. I need you to know that."

The words landed heavy in my chest. I couldn't deal with them, couldn't process what they meant.

"I have to go," I said.

He didn't try to stop me.

I went downstairs and straight to the shower. I washed every inch of my body, scrubbing until my skin turned pink. I washed my hair twice. I stood under the water until it ran cold and I still didn't feel clean.

When I finally got out I looked at myself in the mirror. I looked the same as I had this morning. Same face, same body. But I was different now. I was someone who cheated. Someone who lied. Someone who had sex with another man while her boyfriend sat in class studying urban planning.

The guilt was overwhelming. It filled my chest, my throat, my skull. I sat on the bathroom floor and cried, quiet sobs that shook my whole body. I cried for what I had done, for what I was becoming, for the person I used to be.

But even through the tears, even through the guilt, I knew I would do it again.

Silas came home at eight-fifteen. I was on the couch pretending to read. He kissed the top of my head and went to the kitchen.

"How was your day?" he asked.

"Fine. Quiet."

"I brought Thai food. You hungry?"

"Not really."

He came to the couch with his plate and sat beside me. "You feeling okay? You look tired."

"Just a long day at work."

"You should take it easy tomorrow."

"Yeah. Maybe."

We ate in front of the television. I forced down a few bites to keep up appearances. His leg pressed against mine and I felt nothing but revulsion. Not at him, but at myself. At what I had done. At what I was still doing.

That night in bed he reached for me again. I couldn't do it. I couldn't let him touch me, not tonight, not with Myles still on my skin in ways no shower could wash away.

"I'm not feeling well," I said. "My stomach."

"Oh. Okay." He rolled over without question, without concern.

I lay awake until dawn, listening to him breathe, thinking about choices and consequences and the lies we tell ourselves to survive.

The next two weeks developed a pattern. I would tell myself I was done. I would avoid the laundry room, avoid the windows that faced the driveway, avoid any chance of running into Myles. I would focus on Silas, on making dinner and asking about his thesis and trying to rebuild something that had been broken long before Myles appeared.

It never lasted more than a few days.

I would find myself standing at his door. Or he would catch me in the driveway. Or I would see him through the window and my resolve would crumble. We would end up pressed against each other, hands searching, mouths hungry, stopping just short of the final line.

Each time we got closer. His fingers inside me while I stroked him. My mouth on him until he finished. His tongue bringing me to the edge again and again. But we hadn't crossed that last boundary. The one that would make this undeniably, irreversibly real.

The guilt never went away. It sat in my chest like a stone, heavy and constant. I would leave Myles's apartment and go downstairs and look at Silas and hate myself. But the hatred wasn't strong enough to stop me. Nothing was strong enough to stop me.

On a Thursday afternoon, three weeks after that first kiss in the laundry room, I was getting ready for work when I heard a knock on our apartment door. Silas was in the shower. I opened it.

Myles stood in the stairwell.

My heart stopped. "What are you doing here?"

"I needed to see you."

"You can't be here. Silas is home."

"I know. I heard the shower." He stepped inside before I could stop him. "I haven't seen you in four days."

"I've been busy."

"You've been avoiding me."

He was right. I had been trying again to stop, to end this before it consumed everything. But standing there looking at him, I felt my resolve dissolving.

"You need to leave," I said.

"Not until you tell me what's going on. Are we done?"

"I don't know."

"That's not an answer."

The shower shut off. We both heard it. Myles glanced toward the bathroom, then back at me.

"I need to see you," he said quietly. "Tomorrow. Tell him you're working a double shift."

The bathroom door opened. Silas emerged in a towel, water dripping from his hair. He stopped when he saw Myles.

"Hey," Silas said. "You're the guy from upstairs, right?"

"Myles. 12." Myles extended his hand and Silas shook it, casual and unsuspecting.

"What's up?"

"I was looking for the building manager. Thought Briana might know how to reach them. Problem with my sink."

"Oh. Yeah, the number's on the fridge." Silas gestured toward the kitchen, then went to the bedroom to get dressed.

Myles looked at me. The lie had come so easily from him, smooth and complete. We were both good at this now, at the deception.

"I'll text you the number," I said, my voice steady.

"Thanks." He held my gaze for a moment too long, then left.

I closed the door and leaned against it, my heart racing. That was too close. Too risky. But part of me had thrilled at it, at having them both in the same room, at the dangerous edge of almost being caught.

Silas came out dressed. "Nice guy."

"Yeah."

"You know him well?"

"Not really. Just from the laundry room. We talk sometimes."

Another lie. They stacked up so easily now, building a wall between us.

I lasted until Friday evening. I told Silas I was picking up a coworker's shift, that I wouldn't be home until late. He nodded without looking up from his laptop.

"There's leftover pizza," he said.

"Okay."

"See you later."

I went upstairs to 12 with my pulse racing. I knocked and Myles opened immediately, like he'd been waiting. He pulled me inside and kissed me before the door even closed.

"Four days," he said between kisses. "That's too long."

"I know."

His hands were already under my shirt, sliding up my ribs. I gripped his shoulders and kissed him back, all the resistance I'd built up over four days crumbling in seconds. He walked me backward into the apartment, our mouths never separating.

We made it to the couch. He sat and pulled me onto his lap, facing him. I straddled him and felt him already hard beneath his jeans. The knowledge sent heat pooling between my legs.

"I thought about you," he said, his mouth moving to my neck. "Every night. Every morning. I can't stop."

"Me too."

His hands slid under my shirt and pulled it over my head. My bra followed. He looked at me in the lamplight, his eyes dark with want.

"You're so beautiful," he said.

He took my breast in his mouth and I arched into him, my hands in his hair. His tongue circled my nipple while his hand worked the other, rolling and pinching until I was gasping. I rocked against him, seeking friction, seeking relief.

"Bedroom," I said. "Please."

He stood with me wrapped around him and carried me through the door. He laid me on the bed and pulled off my jeans, my underwear. Then I was naked and he was still dressed and the imbalance made me ache.

"Your turn," I said.

He stripped quickly. I watched him in the soft light from the window. The lean muscle of his torso, the defined lines of his abdomen. When he pushed down his jeans he was thick and hard, ready.

He moved over me, settling between my legs. His weight felt right, necessary. He kissed me deep and slow while his hand slid between us, fingers finding me already wet.

"God, you're ready," he said.

"I'm always ready for you."

He stroked me slowly, his thumb circling while two fingers slid inside. I gasped and my hips lifted off the bed. He worked me with steady pressure, watching my face, learning what made my breathing change.

"I love watching you," he said. "The way you respond to me."

I couldn't form words. His fingers curved inside me, hitting that spot that made everything tighten. His thumb maintained steady pressure and I

felt myself climbing, my thighs starting to shake.

"That's it," he said. "Let me see you."

The tension built and built until I broke apart, my body clenching around his fingers in waves that rolled through me. He worked me through it, gentling as I came down, then building me up again before I could catch my breath.

"Please," I said. "I need you."

He reached for the nightstand and pulled out a condom. I watched him tear it open with shaking hands. This was it. The final line. Everything we had done before could be rationalized somehow, minimized. But this was different.

"Briana," he said, holding the condom. "Are you sure?"

I thought about Silas downstairs. About the three years we had spent together. About trust and promises and the person I used to be. The guilt rose up thick and choking.

Then I thought about the way Myles looked at me. The way he made me feel alive. I thought about the basement apartment and the dissertation and the slow death of living with someone who had stopped seeing me.

"Yes," I said. "I'm sure."

He rolled on the condom and positioned himself between my legs. The head of him pressed against me, hot and insistent. His eyes met mine.

"Tell me if you want me to stop," he said.

I pulled him down into a kiss instead of answering. He pushed inside slowly and I gasped at the stretch. He was thick, filling me completely. Every inch felt deliberate, felt like a choice I was making with my whole body.

When he was fully inside he stopped, letting me adjust. His forehead rested against mine, both of us breathing hard.

"You feel incredible," he said.

"Move. Please move."

He pulled back slowly, almost all the way out, then thrust back in. The sensation made my eyes close. He found a rhythm, steady and deep, each thrust deliberate. I wrapped my legs around him, changing the angle, taking him deeper.

"Yes," I breathed. "Like that."

His mouth found my neck, kissing and biting gently. One hand gripped my hip, holding me steady. The other slid between us, his thumb finding my

clit. The dual sensation made me cry out.

"You have to be quiet," he said against my ear. "Unless you want him to hear you."

The reminder of Silas directly below us should have stopped me. Instead it made everything more intense. The wrongness of it, the danger, fed something dark inside me.

Myles increased his pace, thrusting harder. The sound of skin against skin filled the room. His thumb circled faster and I felt myself climbing again, the pressure building low in my core.

"I want to feel you come around me," he said. "I want to feel you fall apart."

His words pushed me over the edge. I clenched around him, my body pulsing in waves. He groaned and his rhythm faltered. He thrust hard one more time and I felt him stiffen, felt him finish inside me.

He collapsed against me, both of us breathing hard. His weight pressed me into the mattress and I didn't want him to move. I wanted to stay like this, joined, the world narrowed to just our bodies.

Eventually he pulled out and dealt with the condom. I lay there feeling hollowed out, destroyed in the best way. He came back to bed and pulled me against his chest.

"Stay," he said. "Just for a while."

I should have left immediately. Should have run back downstairs before Silas wondered where I was. Instead I let Myles hold me, his hand stroking my hair, his heartbeat steady under my ear.

"What time does he expect you home?" he asked.

"Late. I told him I was working until closing."

"Then we have hours."

I turned to look at him. "You want me to stay?"

"I want you to stay forever. But I'll take what I can get."

The tenderness in his voice made my chest tight. I kissed him to avoid responding, and the kiss deepened into something else. His hands moved over my body, learning me, and I felt him hardening against my hip.

"Again?" I asked.

"I can't help it. You're here and you're naked and you're mine."

"I'm not yours."

"For tonight you are."

He rolled me onto my back and kissed his way down my body. His mouth found my breast, then moved lower, across my ribs, my stomach. When he reached my thighs he spread them wide and settled between them.

"What are you doing?" I asked.

"Tasting you."

His tongue slid through my folds and I gasped. He licked and sucked, his hands gripping my thighs to hold me open. The sensation was overwhelming. I tangled my fingers in his hair, not sure if I was pulling him closer or pushing him away.

He slid two fingers inside me while his mouth worked my clit. The combination made my back arch off the bed. He found that spot inside me and pressed, his tongue circling, and I felt everything tighten.

"Myles," I gasped. "I can't, "

"Yes you can. Give me another one."

He increased the pressure, his fingers curving, his tongue relentless. The climax built fast and broke hard, making my thighs shake around his head. He worked me through it until I pushed at his shoulders, too sensitive.

He kissed his way back up my body, his mouth finding mine. I could taste myself on his tongue.

"Your turn," I said when I could speak.

I pushed him onto his back and straddled him. He was hard again, ready. I positioned myself over him and sank down slowly, taking him inch by inch. From this angle he filled me completely, hit different spots. I rolled my hips and we both groaned.

"God, Briana. You're perfect like this."

I started to move, finding a rhythm. His hands gripped my hips, guiding me. I leaned forward, changing the angle, and he hit that spot inside me that made my eyes roll back.

"There," I said. "Right there."

I rode him harder, chasing my own pleasure. His hands moved to my breasts, rolling my nipples between his fingers. The added sensation pushed me higher. I could feel another climax building, impossible, my body already wrung out.

"Touch yourself," he said. "I want to watch you make yourself come."

I slid my hand between us and found my clit. The combination of him inside me and my own fingers made me gasp. I worked myself while I rode him, my movements becoming erratic as I got closer.

"That's it," he said. "Use me. Take what you need."

I came hard, my body clenching around him. He gripped my hips and thrust up into me, prolonging it. When I collapsed forward he rolled us over, never pulling out.

"My turn," he said.

He hooked my legs over his shoulders, folding me nearly in half, and thrust deep. From this angle he hit places nothing had hit before. I gripped the sheets and took it, took him, gave myself over to the sensation completely.

He pounded into me, his breathing ragged, chasing his release. When it hit him he buried himself deep and groaned my name. I felt him pulse inside me and the intimacy of it, the rawness, made tears sting my eyes.

He pulled out carefully and collapsed beside me. We lay there catching our breath, our bodies slick with sweat.

"Jesus," he said.

"Yeah."

He turned his head to look at me. "You okay?"

"I don't know what I am."

He pulled me against him, tucking my head under his chin. "You're here. That's enough for now."

We dozed. When I woke the room was darker, evening settling in. Myles was awake, his hand tracing idle patterns on my back.

"What time is it?" I asked.

"Almost eight."

I sat up. "I need to go."

"Not yet."

"Myles, "

"Five more minutes. Just give me five more minutes."

I lay back down. He held me close and I let myself have this, just for a moment. Let myself pretend this was my life, that I could wake up next to him every morning, that there was no Silas downstairs waiting for me.

But reality was waiting. It was always waiting.

I got dressed slowly, my body sore in places I wasn't used to. Myles watched from the bed, still naked.

"When can I see you again?" he asked.

"I don't know."

"Tomorrow. Tell him you're going for a run."

"Maybe."

"Briana."

I looked at him. He sat up, his expression serious.

"This isn't just sex for me," he said. "I need you to know that. It stopped being just sex the first time we talked."

The words hit me hard. I couldn't process them, couldn't let them be real.

"Don't," I said.

"Don't what? Don't tell you the truth?"

"Don't make this harder than it already is."

I left before he could say anything else.

I went downstairs feeling like I was made of glass, fragile and transparent. Surely Silas would look at me and know. Surely he would see what I had become.

He was at the kitchen table with his laptop. He looked up when I came in.

"How was work?"

"Exhausting."

"You look tired. There's leftover pizza if you want it."

"I'm not hungry."

I went straight to the shower and stood under water as hot as I could stand. I could still feel Myles inside me, could still feel his hands on my hips, his mouth on my skin. I scrubbed until I was raw but the feeling didn't go away.

When I came out, Silas was already in bed, his back to me. I climbed in beside him and stared at the ceiling. I had done it. I had crossed every line, destroyed every boundary. There was no going back.

And the worst part was I wanted to do it again.

I lasted less than twenty-four hours.

Saturday morning I woke early and put on my running clothes. Silas was still asleep. I went upstairs and knocked softly on Myles's door.

He opened it shirtless, his eyes darkening when he saw me.

"Couldn't stay away?" he said.

"Apparently not."

He pulled me inside. Our mouths met before the door even closed. His hands went to the hem of my tank top and pulled it over my head. My

sports bra followed. He cupped my breasts, his thumbs brushing over my nipples until they hardened.

I worked at his sweatpants, pushing them down. He was already hard. I wrapped my hand around him and he groaned into my mouth.

"Bedroom," he said.

"No time. Here."

He lifted me and I wrapped my legs around his waist. He pressed me against the door and positioned himself. One thrust and he was inside me. We both gasped at the sudden fullness.

He moved fast, each thrust pushing me harder against the door. I buried my face in his neck to muffle my sounds. His hands gripped my thighs, his fingers digging in hard enough to leave marks. The rough edge of it sent heat through me.

I tightened around him as the pressure built. He shifted his angle and hit something inside me that made my vision blur. Three more thrusts and I was falling apart, my body clenching around him in waves. He followed moments later, his whole body going rigid.

We stayed like that, pressed against the door, breathing hard. Finally he lowered me and I dressed quickly.

"Tomorrow?" he asked.

"Maybe."

But we both knew it wasn't maybe.

Sunday I went up. Monday I told Rachel I felt sick and left work early. Tuesday Silas had an evening class and I went upstairs the moment his car pulled out of the driveway.

Myles opened the door and pulled me inside. This time we made it to the bedroom. He laid me on the bed and pulled off my jeans, my underwear. Then he settled between my legs and put his mouth on me.

His tongue moved in slow circles, then long strokes. He slid two fingers inside me while his mouth continued its work. I gripped the sheets and tried to stay quiet but small sounds escaped anyway. He curved his fingers and found that spot and I arched off the bed.

The climax built slowly, then crashed over me all at once. My thighs shook around his head. He didn't stop, kept working me until I pushed at his shoulders, too sensitive.

He kissed his way up my body. I could taste myself on his tongue. He reached for a condom and rolled it on, then positioned himself and pushed

inside in one smooth movement.

This time was slower. He pulled almost all the way out, then slid back in with deliberate care. Each stroke was measured, controlled. He watched my face as he moved, learning what made my breath catch.

"Touch yourself," he said.

I slid my hand between us. The combination made everything tighter, more intense. He maintained that slow rhythm while I worked myself. The dual sensation built something different than before, deeper and more overwhelming.

When it broke I bit down on his shoulder. He thrust harder, faster, chasing his own finish. I felt his pulse inside me and then he was collapsing against me, both of us breathing hard.

We lay tangled together afterward. His hand traced patterns on my back. Neither of us spoke. There was nothing to say that wouldn't make this more complicated than it already was.

Eventually I got up and dressed. He watched from the bed.

"Same time tomorrow?" he asked.

I should have said no. Should have established some kind of boundary. Instead I nodded and left.

Wednesday afternoon Silas was home, working in our bedroom. I told him I was going to do laundry. Instead I climbed the stairs to 12.

Myles answered already pulling off his shirt. He pulled me inside and we moved straight to the bedroom. We had maybe twenty minutes, thirty if I was lucky.

He pushed me onto the bed and pulled off my jeans. No warm-up this time, no slow build. He thrust inside me and I had to bite the pillow to keep quiet. One hand covered my mouth while the other gripped my hip. He moved hard and fast, both of us racing against the clock.

I finished first, my body clenching around him. He followed moments later, his fingers digging into my skin.

"Tomorrow?" he asked as I got dressed.

"He'll be home again."

"So come when he's in the shower. Or tell him you're getting the mail. I don't care. Just come."

I went back downstairs with my heart racing. Silas was exactly where I left him, typing away. He didn't even look up when I came in.

"That was fast," he said.

"Small load."

Thursday evening Silas left for a study group. The moment his car left I was upstairs. Myles opened the door and pulled me inside.

"How long do I have you?" he asked.

"Three hours."

"Good."

He took me to the bedroom and laid me on the bed. Then he spent time just touching me. His hands moved over my body, learning, exploring. He kissed my neck, my collarbone, the curve of my waist. His mouth found my breast and he took his time there, sucking and licking until I was squirming beneath him.

He kissed down my stomach, my hip bones. His mouth moved along my inner thigh but he avoided where I needed him most. I reached for his head, trying to guide him, but he caught my wrists and pinned them above me.

"Not yet," he said.

He continued the slow exploration. His tongue traced patterns on my skin. His teeth grazed sensitive spots. By the time he finally put his mouth between my legs I was nearly shaking with need.

He worked me slowly, building me up and bringing me back down. Just when I thought I would finish, he would pull back, kiss my thigh, wait. Then start again. He did this three times, four, until I was making sounds I didn't recognize.

When he finally let me come it was so intense I saw stars. My whole body went taut and then released in waves that seemed endless.

Before I could recover he flipped me onto my stomach. He pulled my hips up and positioned himself behind me. This angle was deeper, almost too much. He gripped my hair and pulled my head back as he thrust.

"Look at me," he said.

I turned my head and met his eyes. The intensity in his gaze made my stomach drop. He maintained eye contact as he moved, each thrust deliberate. I gripped the sheets and took it, took him, my body already building toward another finish.

He released my hair and both hands went to my hips, holding me steady as he increased his pace. The sound of skin against skin filled the room. I pressed my face into the pillow to muffle my sounds.

When I came again it was harder than before, my body clenching around him so tight he groaned. He thrust twice more and then stilled, his fingers

digging into my hips hard enough to bruise.

After, we lay tangled in his sheets. His hand traced idle patterns on my back. We didn't talk. The silence felt safer than words.

Eventually I got up and dressed. He watched from the bed.

"Tomorrow?" he asked.

"Maybe."

But we both knew it was yes.

Friday afternoon I was getting ready for work when my phone buzzed.

Come up. Now. Before you leave.

I looked at the clock. Fifteen minutes before I needed to leave. Silas was in the shower.

I went upstairs.

Myles pulled me inside and pushed me against the wall. His mouth found mine while his hand slid into my jeans. He worked me with his fingers until I was gasping against his shoulder.

"Turn around," he said.

I turned and he pressed me face-first against the wall. He pulled my jeans down just enough and positioned himself. One hard thrust and he was inside me. The angle was tight, almost uncomfortable. He gripped my hips and moved fast, both of us aware of the ticking clock.

My hands pressed flat against the wall for balance. Each thrust pushed me harder against it. The edge of pain mixed with pleasure made everything sharper, more intense.

I finished fast, biting my lip to stay quiet. He thrust three more times and then went still, his forehead pressed between my shoulder blades.

We stood like that for a moment, both breathing hard. Then he pulled out and I yanked up my jeans with shaking hands.

"Tonight," he said. "After work. Come back."

"Okay."

I went downstairs and finished getting ready. Silas came out of the bathroom in a towel.

"You're going to be late," he said.

"I know. I got distracted."

That night I worked my shift and then went straight upstairs instead of going home. It was past eleven. Silas would be asleep or close to it.

Myles was waiting. He opened the door and pulled me inside. This time we didn't rush. He undressed me slowly, his hands patient. He laid me on

the bed and took his time, using his mouth on every part of me.

When he finally pushed inside me it felt different than the frantic afternoon session. This was deliberate, unhurried. He moved slowly, each stroke deep and measured. His eyes stayed on mine and I couldn't look away.

He brought me to the edge and held me there, slowing down whenever I got too close. My hands gripped his shoulders, my nails leaving marks. He kissed me while he moved, swallowing my sounds.

When he finally let me finish it rolled through me in long waves. He followed moments later, his rhythm faltering.

After, I lay against his chest. His hand moved through my hair in slow strokes. I knew I should leave but I couldn't make myself move.

"Stay," he said quietly.

I almost did. Almost let myself have one full night. But that felt like too much, like crossing a different kind of line.

"I can't."

He didn't argue. Just held me until I finally got up and got dressed.

At home, Silas was asleep on the couch, his laptop still open. I covered him with a blanket and went to bed alone. My body ached in familiar places. I fell asleep thinking about Myles's hands on me, his mouth, the way he looked at me like I was the only thing in the world that mattered.

The guilt was there, always there. But it was background noise now. The foreground was filled with him.